

Q What should I do when I first find out that I am pregnant?

Call your OB/GYN's office and make an appointment. They will schedule your first appointment when you are six to eight weeks pregnant. If you have any abnormal bleeding or other concerns, they may want to see you sooner than that.

You may be asked when the first day of your last menstrual period (LMP) was, in order to calculate an estimated date of delivery (EDD), or due date. Give your doctor a rough idea if you don't know this date for sure; you'll be offered an ultrasound at around 12 weeks pregnant to assess the due date more accurately (see p.95).

You will need to tell your doctor about the history of any previous pregnancies (including terminations), any health issues you have, and any relevant family medical history for both you and the baby's father. If you're taking medications, have them with you, so he or she can tell you if it's safe to continue taking them. Be prepared to say how long it has taken you to get pregnant (if you've been trying), and if you had fertility treatment. In the latter case, you will have an early ultrasound to confirm the pregnancy and make sure all is well (see p.94).

You can be asked about your diet, alcohol consumption, and any smoking or drug use. It's important to be honest in your answers since this appointment is an opportunity to ensure that you get the best available care for yourself and your baby. Everything you tell your doctor is confidential—and it will benefit the health of your baby.

Finally, you will be given information on nutrient supplements to take (including folic acid and vitamin D), food safety, nutrition, and the various screening tests available to you in pregnancy.

Your doctor can answer any concerns you have about your pregnancy at any time throughout your nine months, whether about your own health or that of your baby.

Q Who will take care of my health, and that of my baby, during pregnancy?

If you have a straightforward pregnancy, your regular checkups will be done at your doctor's office by an OB/GYN rather than at a hospital. In some cases you will have one primary contact. Other women see several doctors.

Your OB/GYN (the doctor you see at your initial pregnancy appointment) may be your primary caregiver throughout. He or she will take your blood and urine samples, measure your blood pressure, and check the growth and well-being of your baby. He or she will also book your ultrasounds and be a regular point of contact for support and advice.

If your pregnancy is not straightforward, (if you have a multiple pregnancy, preexisting conditions, or risk factors, or if any factors develop during your pregnancy), you may be referred to a specialist for additional care.

If your doctor is part of a practice with two or more OB/GYNs, he or she will want you to have at least one prenatal appointment with each doctor in the practice, so that you'll get to know each one. You don't know who will be on call at the hospital when you go into labor.

Health-care professionals you may meet during your pregnancy include:

» **Your OB/GYN** is the first person to see when you become pregnant. You should continue to consult your OB/GYN during pregnancy about other health problems and medication.

» **The other doctors in your OB/GYN's practice** (if you're not seeing a solo practitioner) will conduct some of your prenatal appointments. The doctors should take turns monitoring you throughout your pregnancy so that you meet everyone.

» **A sonographer** is someone who is specially trained to use and take readings from an ultrasound scanner in order to monitor the intrauterine health of your baby.

» **A maternal-fetal medicine specialist** is an OB/GYN who treats women with high-risk pregnancies. If you have a preexisting chronic health condition or you're carrying multiples, your doctor may refer you to this specialist for some or all of your appointments.

Q Can I make sure I've understood?

Q Can you explain it again?

Q Is there a pamphlet I can take home?



You can always ask questions Quiz any health-care professional you meet. There is often a lot of new information to absorb; asking the three questions suggested above can help make things clearer.

» **A midwife** may be an alternate caregiver to an OB/GYN. A certified professional midwife may be your primary caregiver during your pregnancy if you are healthy, expect to have a normal, uneventful pregnancy and know that you'd like to have your baby at a birth center. A certified nurse midwife may do hospital deliveries.

» **An anesthesiologist** is a doctor who specializes in pain relief and anesthesia. You'll see an anesthesiologist if you ask for an epidural in labor, or if you have a C-section.

» **A nurse practitioner** may work in your OB/GYN's office and see you for routine prenatal appointments. She can take your measurements and give you routine tests but won't be available when you go into labor.